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Critical evaluation of Pakistan's counter-narrative efforts

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ABSTRACT

Counter-narrative is considered an integral component of soft counter-terrorism approaches. This paper examines the case study of Egypt and Pakistan, while keeping the former as a reference point to critically evaluate the counter-narrative campaign of the latter in light of Aristotle's classic work 'Rhetoric'. Credibility and character of messenger, according to Aristotle, is the most potent weapon in one's rhetorical arsenal. The paper argues that the public narrative produced and disseminated by the state of Pakistan contains all necessary elements of effective persuasion sans credible messengers, who should ideally come from the peer group of target audience. Besides highlighting the need for a credible messenger, we propose some policy interventions aimed at projecting the state as a responsible and motherly entity. The paper concludes that the state narrative can successfully recapture its political and moral legitimacy through portraying her role not only as the custodian of Islam and defender of Pakistani Muslims but also the provider of equal economic opportunities, good governance and swift justice.

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Introduction

Narrative, according to Ricoeur, is the art of knitting together seemingly disconnected events into a meaningful story (Ricoeur, 1991, pp. 22–30). When political scientists or players employ this approach, it is done with an intention to influence the political actions of the target audience. Counter-narrative refers to any effort by the counter-terrorist that seeks to deconstruct the militants' ideology and effectively challenge it with an aim to create an environment that counteracts the militants' narrative.

The narrative is divided into different types and to critically evaluate Pakistan's efforts to counter militants' narrative, gauge its effectiveness and completeness, it is imperative to understand different types of narratives and how they relate to each other. The first type, collective narratives, are non-institutionalised, anonymous and common-sense stories known to everyone (Steinmetz, 1992, p. 409). Such narratives usually evolve organically, with no author, but enjoy widespread acceptability in society. Borrowing an example cited by Hsu, widespread stories of prevalent corruption in China in the 1990s fall in the category of collective narratives. Similarly, in Pakistan, commonly known stories of the corrupt ruling elite of the country also fit in this category. There is hardly a single lesson in school textbooks on this topic but everyone knows it. Closely linked

to collective narratives are ontological narratives, which are also known as stories told by ordinary people. They differ from collective narratives on the basis of widespread acceptability. 'When a certain ontological narrative plot becomes widely established as standard explanations, these evolve into collective narratives' (Hsu, 2001). The third and most important type, from this article's perspective, is public narrative. This particular form deals specifically with the 'stories' constructed, published and disseminated by actors in the public sphere such as the government, intellectuals, media, clergy and political organisations (Hsu, 2001; Steinmetz, 1992). Ideally, public narratives must be built on collective narratives to seek widespread acceptance.

The public narrative on the national identity of Pakistan was constructed with Islam as a binding force for diverse ethnic groups of the country. The state was staged as the guardian of Islam and Muslims in and around the country. During the early years of inception of the country, policy-makers adopted a liberal interpretation of Islam at the cost of displeasing the literalist clergy. Scholars such as Allama Muhammad Asad, an Austro-Hungarian Jewish convert to Islam, were placed in high official positions and tasked to head the Department of Islamic Reconstruction, a body created to align Pakistani law, education system and governance practices in accordance with the Quran. Qasmi also noted that highly educated scholars including Ghulam Ahmed Pervaiz, Dr Fazl ur Rehman and Dr Javaid Iqbal advised the government on matters pertaining to Islam, which resulted into an inclusive and non-sectarian national narrative (Kamran, 2016). This narrative was also in-line with the vision of the founder of Pakistan, who emphasised Muslim modernism, categorically rejecting ideas such as pan-Islamism (Zaidi, 1993, p. 485).¹

The national narrative of Pakistan gradually came to adopt heavy Islamic overtones in the 1970s mainly due to tectonic shifts in the internal and regional politics of the country. A new generation of literalists came to assume more prominence and authority in policy-making circles. Moderate scholars were either side-lined, as was the case with Allama Muhammad Asad, or demonised, as was the case with Ghulam Ahmed Pervaiz. The literalists imported narrative heroes largely from Central Asia and the Middle East without indigenising them to local culture and norms. Since the means of communication were limited and tightly controlled, alternate narratives found it hard to penetrate in the society. Eventually, the ideology nurtured during the 1970s and 80s laid the foundations of a narrative that would come to haunt the state and society of Pakistan in the decades to come.

During initial few years of the twenty-first century, disgruntled Jihadis drew upon the traditionalist Pan-Islamic and sectarian narrative to demonise the state of Pakistan for damaging Islam and for the collective sufferings of Muslims in and around the country. The neo-Taliban groups such as the TTP, Al-Qaeda in the Indian subcontinent and Jamat-ul-Ahrar essentially rewrote the narratives hitherto used by the state to ensure national cohesion and draw legitimacy from the masses. In doing so, they successfully threatened the political and moral authority of the ruling elite and different organs of the state including Pakistan Army. However, following the Army Public School attack (December 2014), the state revised the story that had been damaging Islam and was responsible for the sufferings of Muslims. Official and private media portrayed the state fighting the enemies of Islam (terrorist organisations) on behalf of the Muslims of Pakistan (projecting them as the primary victims of violent extremism unleashed in the name of protecting Islam). In this effort to reclaim the narrative,

the role of the state is staged as the defender of Islam and Muslims against their brutal onslaught by terrorists.

Using Narrative theory, this paper aims to critically evaluate Pakistan's efforts to reclaim the national narrative. After a brief discussion of multi-causality underlying terrorism and the need for a counter-narrative, the theory of narrative analysis is explained with detail, its strengths, limitations and possible steps to address those limitations in order to draw a comprehensive critique of Pakistan's measures to counter militants' narrative. The Second section of the paper discusses Egypt's counter-narrative efforts in light of narrative theory and the Basic Communication Model. Here, the case study of Egypt is discussed in detail as an objective standard to compare, contrast and analyse the case study of Pakistan. A qualitative case study without an external point of reference is prone to inaccurate conclusions (Simons, 2009). The standardisation of Egypt's counter-narrative efforts as a reference point for gauging the effectiveness of Pakistan's efforts helps in reducing the subjectivity that is consistent in qualitative case studies. Using the same theory and model, the third section first provides an overview of the steps taken by the government of Pakistan to defuse militants' narrative and subsequently moves on to critically analyse the gaps in light of 'Narrative Analysis' and the 'Basic Communication Model'.

The paper concludes that the national counter-narrative efforts can be more effective if the state manages to stage and reorient itself as a benevolent, just and functional entity, rather than merely an ideological guardian and protector of Islam and Muslims.

Contextualising terrorism and the need for a counter-narrative

Terrorism is a bi-product of extremism, which occurs at three different levels i.e. at the level of individuals, organisations and the environment. Multi-level analysis of violent extremism also suggests that factors driving an individual to resort to terrorism differ significantly from the factors that motivate terrorist organisations. For instance, in Pakistan, the majority of the fighters appear to be driven by a motivation of vengeance and religious fundamentalism, but terrorist organisations use this tactic (terrorism) because it is more effective than other means (democratic struggle, penetrating the society and implementing *Shariah*). Similarly, few segments of Pakistani society that subscribe to extremists' worldview may be driven by an entirely different set of motives (Iqbal, 2016). Hence, multi-causality of violent extremism demands a multi-level approach that dissects root-causes and recommends remedies tailored specifically for each level.

Any Counter-Terrorism (CT) strategy is divided into two major components i.e. hard CT and soft CT. Whereas hard CT deals with killing and capturing terrorists, soft CT mainly relies on identifying, preventing and pre-empting violent extremism through non-coercive means. The two approaches are not mutually exclusive. But numbers of research studies have established that counter-insurgency and counter-terrorism is 20 per cent military and 80 per cent political (Galula, 1964, p. 66). Political and non-coercive measures including de-radicalisation, rehabilitation and counter-narratives fall under the broader category of political or soft CT. Counter-narratives can potentially

cure violent extremism at all three levels i.e. individual, organisational and environmental.

Scholars critical of counter-narrative policies offer two reasons for rejecting the need for a counter-narrative, firstly terrorists are brainwashed to a point of no-return, therefore counter-narratives may amount to a waste of resources. Secondly, causes of violent extremism are rooted in structural factors such as poverty, corruption, lack of justice, bad governance etc. Unless the state takes effective measures to address the structural factors, 'cosmetic measures' such as counter-narratives may have limited or no effect in eradicating extremism in both its violent and non-violent manifestations. Both objections are, however, flawed. Firstly, there are three levels of participation in terrorism i.e. sympathisers, supporters and active combatants. Active combatants are often numerically very few and draw from a vast pool of sympathisers and supporters. A counter-narrative may not be able to dissuade a handful of active combatants but can potentially encourage millions of sympathisers and supporters to reconsider their options towards a political or ideological end. On the second point of objection, structural factors, no doubt, play a very important motivational role on terrorism in Pakistan (Iqbal). This, however, does not reduce the need for counter-narrative efforts because an effective persuasion model does not only aim to break ideological bonds of individuals to terrorism but also dents their affective and pragmatic commitment to their 'cause' and the organisation championing it (Rabasa, Pettyjohn, Ghez, & Boucek, 2010, p. 7). A good narrative can only depict the state as a responsible and motherly entity if the state's counter-narrative efforts are accompanied by concrete steps to address the structural factors of violent extremism such as poverty-eradication and good governance.

Theoretical underpinning

Narrative or 'Narratology', as it is referred in literary theory, has been useful across various disciplines including communication studies, sociology, psychology, linguistics, anthropology, organisational studies and political science (Egudo & Mitchell, 2003). Labovian's view on the definition of narratives holds that 'narratives are a sequence of past tense main clauses, where the order of the clauses is presumed to follow the order of events' (Linde, 2001). Put simply, narrative can be defined as an art of storytelling in a sequential and cohesive manner to build and convey your own version of reality. In Political Science and political affairs narratives serve to discreetly communicate and legitimise power structures within the polity.

Narrative scholars trace the roots of this theory in Aristotle's classic work 'Rhetoric', which laid the foundation of modern model of mass communication by recognising the significance of audiences of all kinds; listeners, viewers, and spectators. Aristotle's 'Rhetoric' mainly puts much of its emphasis on public speaking by making the use of its five gears; the speaker, speech, occasion, the audience and effect (Braet, 1999). The rhetoric, as defined by Aristotle, is the art of persuasion that includes a persuasive triangle comprising of Ethos, Pathos and Logos. First, **impression/reputation, management and self-portrayal of messenger's character demonstrates his/her necessary trustworthiness – ethos** (Fortenbaugh, 1996; Halloran, 1982). Second, the message, Aristotle believes, should be framed in such a way that has influential appeal for the audience to

think and produce ‘this messenger is like me’ feelings – *pathos*. This part also deals with the emotional aspect of the message to ensure that the message appeals to the feelings, sympathies, hate and contempt of the audience. Finally, the message should be schematic and logical enough to yield the desired effects – *logos* (Fortenbaugh & Johnstone; Halloran). According to the ‘Rhetoric’, in order to achieve the desired results and outcomes it is mandatory to have the persuasive triangle meet the fullest. The speaker needs to use an effective tone so that the message shall comprise the style that is well accepted by the audience for the purpose of desirable outcome.

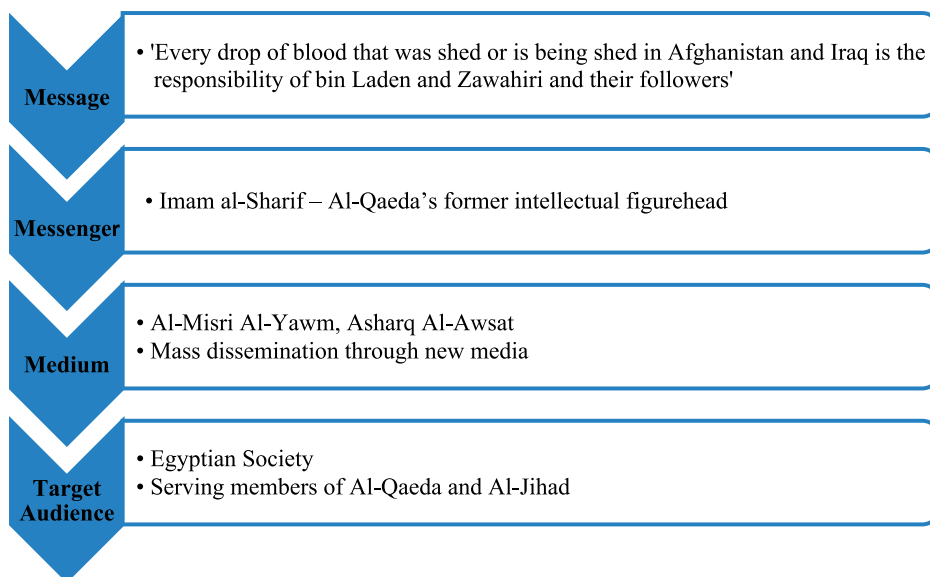
Like any other theory in the Social Sciences, Narrative also suffers from certain limitations, chief among them is subjectivity. Since stories are human constructs, they may be fraught with limits of self-reporting and personal biases. To deal with these limitations, scholars recommend the use of other approaches to complement the storytelling technique. Basic Communication Model (BCM) is one of many readily available frameworks, which dissects stories into four parts on the foundations led by Aristotle. The BCM has four following components;

- (1) Message: Message has to be clear, based on research, encompassing objective and subjective appeal and should be tailored specifically for the target audience.
- (2) Messenger: The messenger needs to be credible because his/her character is the most potent weapon in one’s rhetorical arsenal. The effectiveness of a message can further be enhanced by choosing a messenger from the target audience. Communication specialists believe that behavioural-change messages are more effective if they come from the peer group of the target audience.
- (3) Medium: It is very important to consider how the message is to be delivered. For this purpose, a range of options (from community-oriented channels, to widely circulated newspapers, social and folk media) can be employed.
- (4) Target Audience: The target audience for counter-narrative campaign must not be selected on assumptions but identified through systematic social research.

The Egyptian case study

The combination of ‘Narrative’ (a theory) and Basic Communication Model (a framework) has been employed by a number of governments around the world to craft a narrative to challenge militants’ ideology. In the immediate aftermath of 9/11, the Egyptian government embarked on a systematic campaign to respond to the emerging threat of violent extremism. The government engaged former Jihadi leaders such as Imam Sharif, the ideological founder of Al-Qaeda and a number of imprisoned leaders of Al-Jihad to deal with the ideology of Al-Qaeda and her franchises. During his years of detention in Egyptian prison, Imam Shareef revisited his worldview and wrote a rebuttal of his own writings, criticising the role played by Al-Qaeda and her leaders. His book ‘Rationalising Jihad in Egypt and the World’ called upon Al-Qaeda to seize her operations in Egypt and other parts of the world. The message was disseminated publicly by the Egyptian government to de-radicalise thousands of imprisoned militants and dissuade common Egyptians from falling prey to terrorist

organisations. The following diagram represents the Egyptian efforts of counter-narrative in the frame of Basic Communication Model.



In spite of having a skilfully crafted message, carefully selected mediums and aptly identified the target audience, the Egyptian counter-narrative model suffered from one major problem and that was the credibility of its messenger Imam Sharif alias Dr Fadal. Although he enjoyed widespread respect among the militants' global community, the fact that the book was written during his imprisonment enabled Al-Qaeda leadership to discredit both the message and messenger by claiming that Imam Sharif was either tortured or bribed by the prison authorities to write 'Rationalizing Jihad in Egypt and the World' (Wright, 2008). A prolonged but heated exchange of argument ensued between the followers of Zawahiri and Sharif. To divert the argument in favour of pro-peace context, Arab governments kept facilitating new and more credible messengers, most prominent among them was Imam Yusuf Al-Qardawi, the chief ideologue of Sunni Islam.

Yusuf Qaradawi enjoys very convincing penetration and following all over the Muslim world. His TV show 'Sharia and Life', broadcasted by Al-Jazeera, was followed by millions of Arabic-speaking Muslims all over the world. Apart from writing more than a hundred scholarly books, and hosting one of the most admired websites i.e. IslamOnline, Dr Qardawi also serves as an intellectual and spiritual guide of the Muslim Brotherhood. In his book 'Fiqa-e-Jihad' Dr Qardawi took a centrist position on the issue of Jihad by dividing the perspectives on Jihad into three different categories. The first group of people trivialise Jihad by terming it merely an inner struggle against Satan. The second group of people interpret Jihad as 'fight against the whole world, not distinguishing between those who fight against the Muslims and those who offer peace, protection and reconciliation'. The third set of people is of the ones who have not slipped into the negligence of the first category and likewise, have not fallen into the excess and extremism of the second group. These people, argued Dr Qardawi, are the true Muslims blessed with true knowledge.

The scholarly works such as 'Rationalizing Jihad in Egypt and The World' and 'Fiqa-e-Jihad' are considered as landmarks in the history of terrorism as they successfully transformed 'aggressive frames of minds' of society from obstinacy towards social synchronisation. Similarly, the entire 'intellectual scaffolding' of jihadist warfare became diluted by the overriding argument put forth by the likes of Imam Sharif and Dr Qardawi. This then led to the definite endorsement of Egypt's 'religious modifications' by the majority of leadership of Al-Jihad (Smoltczyk). The outcomes of this whole far-reaching campaign, termed 'The Revisions' by the Egyptian government, were encouraging. Despite having an environment conducive to the growth of violent extremism,² Egypt managed to bring terrorism to a manageable level as the country ranks much lower (compared to Pakistan) on Global Terrorism Index.

The Pakistani case study

The foundation of Pakistan lies in the demand for a separate homeland for the Muslims of Indian Subcontinent. This makes religion an indispensable political reality in the country. However, Islamic principles have been subjected to various interpretations since the inception of the country owing to numerous internal and external political conditions. For example, Zulfikar Ali Bhutto's Socialist portrayal of Islam and General Zia ul Haq's Deobandi version were products of different national and international political circumstances. Changing geo-strategic environment, the use of non-state actors, consistent authoritarian regimes and a lack of consensus on the Islamic way of life are some of the central features of Pakistan's interaction with violent extremism.

In 1958, General Ayub Khan forcibly assumed the political control of the country by imposing Martial Law. Although the following decade saw Pakistan becoming an emerging economy of Asia, there were various other by-products that slowly brewed under this authoritarian regime. As a military dictator, President Ayub was very sensitive to opposition of all kind, and hence during his regime, all political parties were banned (Dawn InpaperMagazine, 2014). Any journalistic endeavour that opposed the regime had to face consequences. As a result of silencing critics and banning political play, the room for constructive criticism and alternative perspectives in the society shrank to nonexistence. His close alliance with the Capitalist block obliged Ayub to eliminate communist movement in Pakistan. As General Ayub cornered the political left, political critique that is the hallmark of leftist politics also became non-existent. Resultantly, the political situation became monotonous and could not absorb the vast political differences present in the country. By denying political representation and space for expressing differences, the probability of extremism increases manifold (Crenshaw, 1981, pp. 389–384), which is what happened during Ayub's regime. Although, in this era, terrorism had not emerged as a phenomenon in Pakistan, the ground was set. The society had become polarised and the regimes that followed translated that extremism into 'holy war'.

With the fall of Dhaka in 1971, Mr Zulfikar Ali Bhutto assumed power. Initially, he was the Chief Martial Law Administrator and later became a democratically elected Prime Minister. Mr Bhutto headed the Pakistan Peoples Party; a party known for its progressive and secular tendencies. However, the political reality of the Bhutto administration was far from their party manifesto. Supposedly from the political left, Bhutto formed a constitution that declared Islam as the state religion of the country. Prima facie, Mr Bhutto was known for his

liberal tastes, but the nature of the religious politics that had been brewing since the Ayub regime (and even before that) made it a political necessity for Mr Bhutto to appease the religious right (Kalasha, 2012). The Council of Islamic Ideology was formed by provision of the 1973 Constitution with more control over the legislative process in comparison to Ayub's 'Advisory' Council of Islamic Ideology. Resultantly, a predominantly Sunni-led group of clerics were tasked to define and limit the framework of any legislation henceforth. This led to actions such as the declaration of Ahmadis as non-Muslims (Pal, 2010) and the prohibition of alcohol in 1977. The polarisation in the society that had started in Ayub regime gained momentum in the political arena in the form of Pakistan National Alliance, a religio-political front, which was formed by the security establishment in opposition to the Bhutto administration. This ripened the conditions for another authoritarian military coup that gave way to further extremism.

In 1978, General Zia ul Haq mounted a coup and Martial Law was imposed in the country. The proclivity of General Zia for Deobandi Islam coupled with the geo-strategic obligations of the time transformed the polarity of the society into violent extremism. In the following years, the Reagan administration worked closely with the Zia regime. Dictatorship was legitimised, radicalisation was facilitated, human rights violations were overlooked, sectarian fault lines became evident and authoritarianism flourished because radicalising a large segment of society to resist Soviet influence in Afghanistan was deemed necessary by USA and Pakistan alike. Hence, non-state actors were armed and equipped with material and ideational tools of war. This can serve as an example of how the means employed to attain strategic objectives can shape a society and have far-reaching consequences. However, by the end of Afghan War, the state of extremism in Pakistan had become very similar to that of Egypt. Pakistan has had a fragile economy and a polarised society consisting of numerous ethnic, lingual, and sectarian fault lines. Religion is a major determinant of her strategic culture that shapes her defence and foreign policy responses³ – that has played adversely by legitimising religious violence. Bad governance, poor government writ in certain areas, rampant corruption, insufficient democracy, fragile civil–military relations, high population growth rate, low literacy, ethno-nationalism, and above all, conservative society with different versions of Islam that value 'holy death' over life – make a befitting mix of extremism and terrorism.

In order to address the menace of terrorism, Pakistan resorted to numerous counter-insurgency and counter-terrorism strategies with varying degrees of success – albeit more emphasis was laid on combating terrorism via hard counter-terrorism. Acute necessity of the counter-narrative was realised by the civil–military leadership of the country since the hard-earned peace dividend, through military efforts, could not be reaped because militants' narrative was deeply entrenched into ordinary masses.

To deal with religious extremism, slanted religious discourses, and resultant terrorism, Pakistan has used various methods to provide opposition to the narrative of violence propagated by religious fundamentalists. Given in Table I is a detailed account of the several counter-narrative measures taken by Pakistan. In its entirety, the thematic substance of the narrative by the state consisted of rightly demonising the terrorist outfits responsible for the ongoing instability. A large number of efforts revolved around composing songs with the message of peace, highlighting the efforts of the Armed Forces against the terrorists. In addition, television dramas, movies and short films were also used as instruments for furthering the counter-narratives. Most of these efforts were undertaken by Inter-Services

Table 1. Source: Eman Malik, Researcher at Inter-Services Public Relations (ISPR) the PR wing of Pakistan Army.

Genre	Title	Themes	Production	Date of publication/ release	Medium
Dramas	Mujahid (A Militant)	Fault lines in Jihad	ISPR Presentation	2008	PTV Home
	<i>Khuda Zameen Sy Gya Nahin</i> (God has not abandoned us!)	Talibans pushed Swat valley to the dark ages	CRS Production and ISPR	2010	PTV Home
	<i>Faseel-e-Jaan Se Aagay</i> (Beyond the boundary of life)	Message of peace and tolerance via tales of individual heroic defiance	CRS Production and ISPR	14 Jan, 2011	PTV Home and Hum TV
	<i>Jaan Hatheli Par</i> (To risk one's life)	Good wins over evil in the end	ISPR Presentation	Dec 2013	PTV Home and Urdu 1
	Nigehbaan (The Guardian)	Pak Army is the custodian of geography and ideology	Gold Bridge Media Presentation	Jan 2015	PTV Home and Hum TV
Movies	<i>Khuda Ke Liye</i> (In the name of God)	Difference of opinion between westernised Muslims and their counterparts	Shoaib Mansoor/Shomaan Production	20 Jul 2007	Pakistani Cinema and Indian Cinema
	<i>Waar</i> (The Strike)	A new perspective to the war on terror	Mind Works Media and Off Road Studios	16 Oct 2013	Pakistani Cinema
	Operation 021	Willingness to give up a part of yourself for something bigger	One Motion Pictures and Azad Film Company and Interactive Studios	6 Oct 2014	Pakistani Cinema
	<i>Maalik</i> (The Owner)	Owning the country as citizens	Media Hub	8 Apr 2016	Pakistani Cinema and United States Cinema
	Revenge of the Worthless	Brutally disfigured cultural narrative during Swat insurgency (2009)	Hunerkada Films	22 Jul 2016	Pakistani Cinema
	Salute	A biopic of shaheed Aitzaz Hasan	Cinetaiment Production	2 Dec 2016	Pakistani Cinema
	<i>Saya-e- Khuda-e Zuljalal</i> (Protection of Magnificent God)	Brilliant emotion-laced battle sequences	Jehan Films and AR Productions	16 Dec 2016	Pakistani Cinema
	<i>Yalghaar</i> (The Assault)	The Pak Army needs you!	Mind Works Media	25 Jun 2017	Pakistani Cinema and other 22 countries
	Project Ghazi (Project of military expedition or raid)	Nationalism but hatred against no one	GYR Films	16 Jul 2017	Pakistani Cinema
	<i>Azam Jawan Salar Hai Apna</i> (Our resolve is leading us)	Unbeaten resolve of the nation	ISPR Presentation	6 Sept 2008	PTV Home and Social Media
Songs	<i>Khuda Zameen Se Gaya Nahi Hai</i> (God has not abandoned us!)	Darkness always precedes the light	ISPR Presentation	2009	PTV Home
	<i>Imtehan Hai Imtehan</i> (It's time to test)	Despondency is turning into hope	ISPR Presentation	2010	PTV Home
	<i>Chadar Hey Maa Ki</i> (The mother's prestige)	Crises of human emotions and tragedy	ISPR Presentation	7 May 2012	Social Media

(Continued)

Table 1. Continued.

Genre	Title	Themes	Production	Date of publication/ release	Medium
Documentaries or Drama Documentaries	<i>Zameen Janti Hai</i> (Soil is our witness)	Soldiers die, so we may live	ISPR Presentation	30 Apr 2013	All Pakistani TV Channels
	<i>Baba Meri Awaz Suno Na</i> (Dad! listen to me)	Son wish to follow the footsteps of his martyred father	ISPR Presentation	30 Apr 2014	Social Media
	<i>Nare Takbeer Allahu Akbar</i> (An Islamic Slogan)	Passion, perseverance, and guts for sacrifice	ISPR Presentation	16 Jul 2014	Social Media
	<i>Mei Pakistan Hoon</i> (I am the Pakistan)	Unity against any threat	ISPR Presentation	7 Mar 2015	Social Media
	<i>Barra Dushman Bana Phirta Hay</i> (Some enemy he is)	Terrorists are cowards	ISPR Presentation	18 Jan 2015	All Pakistani TV Channels and Social Media
	<i>Ye Bandy Mitti Ke Bandy</i> (Real men of soil)	Gallantry is more congenial pursuit of soldiers	ISPR Presentation	2015	All Pakistani TV Channels
	<i>Miti Diay Maye</i> (Soil of land taken as a mother)	A quick glance to reminiscence of mothers of martyrs	ISPR Presentation	6 Sept 2015	All Pakistani TV Channels and Social Media
	<i>Mera Yaar Na Raha</i> (I lost my friend)	Nostalgic glimpse of fathers of martyrs	ISPR Presentation	6 Sept 2015	All Pakistani TV Channels and Social Media
	<i>Tum bhi Mujh Ko Yad Aty ho</i> (I miss you too)	A verbal salute to the bravery of heroes of Army Public School Peshawar	Nadeem Abbas and Ghulam Murtaza	13 Dec 2015	Samaa TV and Social Media
	<i>Khak Jo Khoon Main</i> (Blood infused soil)	Martyrs never die	ISPR Presentation	Sept 2016	Social Media
	<i>Yaarian</i> (Comradeship)	Soldiers live to die another day	ISPR Presentation	6 Sept 2016	Social Media
	<i>Mujhe Dushman ke Bachon Ko Parhana Hai</i> (I have to educate the enemy's children)	Education is the best revenge	ISPR Presentation	15 Dec 2016	All Pakistani TV Channels and Social Media
	<i>Wana Olive</i>	Unvarying vigilance and will of Pak Army against terrorism	An ISPR Project	24 Feb 2006	16th International Film Festival Rome
	<i>The Glorious Resolve</i>	An epic of Infantry arm of Pak Army	ISPR Presentation	22 Feb 2011	You Tube and Social Media
	<i>Black Pearl</i>	Strategic position of Baluchistan and its interlocked tribal war	ISPR Presentation and Hi-Vision Productions	22 Feb 2011	Social Media
	<i>Hum Tum Ko Nhe Bhooley</i> (We have not forgotten you!)	Dark and intense stories of heroic struggle in the shadows of fear	Express News Production	2012	Express News Channel
	<i>Muttasreen</i> (Victims)	Mourning and heartache of the loved ones of martyrs	Samaa TV Production	Mar 2014	Samaa TV Channel

Public Relations, the public relations wing of the Armed Forces. In the media content thus far produced, television dramas and movies have provided a more comprehensive view of the phenomenon of terrorism including its causes, modes of radicalisation and transformation of extremism into terrorism.

The message carried by these infotainment endeavours could not strike the right balance between emotionality and logic. Furthermore, the messenger, the Armed Forces, loses relevance in this case. Since the Armed Forces are party to the conflict, efforts pertaining to narrative building under their auspices are taken with caution by the very people who are supposed to be the subject of ideational change. Resultantly, the debate about the medium of dissemination becomes less relevant.

The clergy has also made efforts to provide a religious rebuttal to the ideology of terrorists. For example, the Pakistan Ulema Council (PUC), under the leadership of Hafiz Muhammad Tahir Ashrafi, issued a fatwa which unanimously, and with clarity, declared groups ranging from ISIS to Hezbollah as illegitimate outfits with no relevance to Islam whatsoever ('Pakistan Ulema Council', 2016). However, the PUC issued fatwa could not engage the masses as well as the members from various other religious sects of the society ('Pakistan Ulema Council'). Furthermore, the chairman of PUC, Tahir Ashrafi, is considered a cleric of dubious credentials and is accused by opposing sects of furthering a very particular religious agenda. Hence, this counter-narrative effort could not gain popularity because the messenger had questionable persuasions.

Another effort to delegitimise terrorism was made by Dr Tahir ul Qadri, in 2010. Dr Qadri issued a 600-page long decree that denounced violent extremism in the name of Islam without granting privileges to any group ('Muslim scholar's', 2010). However, the political persona of Dr Qadri brings his role as a cleric under criticism ('Agitator at large', 2018). A messenger with a tarnished reputation cannot be an able representative of something as sensitive as building a counter-narrative.

The most comprehensive rebuttal to extremism was a collection of fatwas which was unanimously endorsed by all sects of the Muslim community in Pakistan. This effort, *Paigham-e-Pakistan* (PeP), was endorsed by the President of Pakistan. The document is thus far the most comprehensive document which logically refutes the claims of terrorists. The central fatwa comprises 22 points which conclude that terrorism is by no means Islamic and those indulging in anti-state terrorism are doing disservice to Islam (*Paigham-e-Pakistan*, 2018, pp. 40–48). The arguments for 'jihad' which are exploited by militants have been carefully dissected in this document. Firstly, a paradigm shift in the state's approach to armed Jihad can be seen in PeP. Whereas during the Afghan War, efforts were directed toward radicalisation, in PeP, the first chapter explains the actual Islamic code of life which is a religious imperative for all Muslims. The importance of social harmony, spirit of forgiveness, and maintenance of social order have been stressed greatly. Furthermore, PeP, through arguments derived from religious sources, delegitimises militants as a religious or political entity. It very clearly states that only a legitimate political government has the authority to call its people for jihad and no such authority lies with the citizens. The Islamic character of the state has also been discussed at length and a consensus has been formed on the notion that the constitution and the state are not contradictory to Islamic teachings. Hence, the 'jihad' of the militants is not just an attack on the Islamic Republic of Pakistan, but on its people as well; which bears no relation to what jihad actually stands for. There is also a very visible call to resolve sectarian differences

and unite as a nation. In essence, PeP restores the religious and political legitimacy of the state and tries to recalibrate the current social equilibrium with the social rules put forth by Islam.

This particular instance has all the ingredients of a successful counter-narrative. The message is clear and supplemented with references from divine and worldly law. The community of messengers is composed of scholars from all major strands of Islam. The tone is nationalist in nature which gives a unifying point for all members of society. There is but one issue and that is dissemination. For the state to cut off the ideological support groups of terrorists, Paigham-e-Pakistan has to be popularised and endorsed by authorities in their relevant capacities. This document can be instrumental in counter-radicalisation and de-radicalisation efforts of the state. However, the target audience for this message must be selected with great precision.

In totality, Aristotle could not be played out adequately by the decision makers, i.e. sometimes messenger/speakers/norm entrepreneurs were not 'true to character type', they could not persuade audiences by winning their trust; at times the message did not match the type of messenger. Largely, the message was carried by politically exposed and morally compromised people that instead undermined the appeal of the message. In few cases, there emerged prominent credible scholars to publicly challenge violent extremism. But the state could not protect such messengers. For instance, Moulana Sarfraz Naeemi, a vocal religious scholar, who publicly denounced terrorism and described violence directed against civilians and state institutions 'un-Islamic' – was assassinated by terrorists for his pro-state stance. Abdul Ghani Farooq, who helped creating Pakistan's first de-radicalisation program in Swat, met similar fate when he was targeted by the TTP in his clinic.

While talking about the medium to convey the message to the audience, an impartial media is the prerequisite of utmost significance. Pakistan has relied on presumably military driven (party to the problem) media houses that have brought the message and messengers into disrepute. Although historically, Pakistan could not ensure the essential elements of the Basic Communication Model, however, Paigham-e-Pakistan has been successful insofar as the credibility of the message and the messenger is concerned. What remains is the selection of appropriate audiences and adequate modes of disseminating the message.

As for the target audience, defiant youth cannot be appropriate. The older segment of society that has considerable social pressure in Pakistani family life, is excluded to a considerable extent which is a fundamental error, as identified by Aristotle. According to him, for a persuasive performance to achieve desired effects, speakers usually speak in maxims that only suit peer groups. In order to convey a message, the language and tone must be crafted in a way that can penetrate the cognitive biases of the audience.

Characteristics of an effective narrative

It is essential that any counter-narrative effort establish the common 'we' in order to 'otherise' the adversary. A counter-narrative must provide a feeling of commonality for people of diverse ethnic and socio-political backgrounds. In the case of Pakistan, the collective loss of life and infrastructure faced by the people and the state formed a workable ground for the union of the state and the people through a comprehensive counter-narrative.

Pakistan, which represents a unique terror landscape, different contexts with multiple motivations ranging from vengeance (resulted by the counter-productive US Drone campaign and Pakistani military operations in FATA), anti-Americanism (because of the US foreign policy decisions), and religious fundamentalism, to effectiveness of terrorism as a tactic to force the state for their (terrorists') perceived *Sharia* law implementation, requires a multi-layered approach to assess the audience.

Counter-narratives on BCM require careful selection of persuasive appeal, reliable messengers with magnetic personalities, acceptable and understandable mediums, and most importantly the selection of target audiences the change is to be implemented upon. Formers 'extremists and violence-survivors' can form a very useful combination of messengers for public persuasion. In case of their reluctance for the said job, they can also be incentivised with security and financial perks. Muslim societies may consider the translation of the original work of Dr Qardawi (Fiqa-e-Jihad) and Imam Shareef (Rationalising Jihad in Egypt and the World) into their respective national and sub-national languages and disseminate them through local newspapers and Friday prayer leaders (Khateeb) to dissuade individuals and groups from choosing terrorism or using it as a tactic.

Governments should deconstruct, dishonour and reinterpret ideologies that dehumanise potential victims and render them worthy of extinction. Governments should also deconstruct the violent messages of militants by challenging the beliefs of the audience through influential religious figures, emotional appeals, and telling noble lies. However, its success depends on correct identification (that was inappropriate in the case of Pakistan) of the audience that impacts the nature of messages, type of messengers and media to be used. By introducing credible voices that have social influence, governments can ensure social cohesion and political activism. It would be a gross miscalculation on the part of the government to deny the alienation and exclusionary thinking that justifies and promotes slaughter. It is imperative to address the grievances that lead to blaming others and ensure inclusion through democracy. This process must also be coupled with the rectification of issues such as poor governance, fundamental civil rights abuses, religious and racial discrimination. These must be deconstructed and replaced by rule of law, promotion of equality, religious and cultural tolerance.

A good narrative can only present the state as a responsible and motherly entity if the state's counter-narrative efforts are accompanied by concrete steps to address the structural factors of violent extremism such as poverty-eradication and good governance. A narrative must be followed by the reconstruction of war-torn areas so that the recruitment pool of potential terrorists can be transformed into an active segment of society.

Poor education, lack of social inclusion, weak writ of the state, unemployment et cetera. are some of the factors which are consistent with terrorism. Any anti-terrorist narrative shall stand ineffective if the aforementioned causes of terrorism are not rooted out systematically. It is an old philosophical contention that material conditions give birth to the pattern of thought and knowledge structures of a society, if Pakistan's counter-narrative efforts fall short of changing the social conditions which provide a pool of potential terrorists, then the expectation of dislodging terrorist ideology shall be met with a disappointing success rate. Material change is a prerequisite for bringing about ideational change.

According to the UNDP report on Federally Administrated Tribal Areas Transition and Recovery Programme, the rehabilitation programme of war-torn areas must comprise of the following five elements (United Nations Development Programme, 2016):

- (1) Rehabilitating physical infrastructure.
- (2) Strengthening law and order.
- (3) Expanding government service delivery.
- (4) Reactivating and strengthening the economy.
- (5) Strengthening social cohesion and peacebuilding.

If all of the aforementioned elements are combined, a sustainable strategy to halt the process that turns anger and extremism into terrorism can be put in place. For example, if there is infrastructure, law and order, democratic dispensation, vibrant economic opportunities and social cohesion, the causes of anti-state terrorism can be addressed. It is in these circumstances where the state can project itself as a strong motherly entity. Any attempt to challenge the ideology of terrorists without material circumstances that can attest to the state's motherly nature would be nothing but an exercise in futility. In recent times, an initiative was taken by the government to launch an industrial zone in North Waziristan for the rehabilitation of the Temporarily Displaced Persons (TDPs) (Khan, 2017). Such initiatives can greatly increase the chances of creating a successful counter-narrative. Otherwise any counter-narrative would be a collection of empty claims.

Conclusion and policy recommendations

Terrorism is a multi-causal phenomenon. To eradicate terrorism, it is essential that the many causes of terrorism which include unemployment, lack of social awareness and cohesion, economic alienation, identity crises and radical ideology be addressed concurrently. The socio-political landscape of Pakistan is very conducive to terrorism. It is, therefore, essential, that a narrative to counter extremists' ideology must follow the socio-economic reconstruction of Pakistani society at large. The politicisation of Islam in any manner which benefits the state and occasions social stability is not likely to have any tangible effect if it is done in isolation. A strong presence of governance is an inevitable requirement for introducing a softer version of Islam to its adherents.

Pakistan has had to lead wars which were geo-strategically inevitable. Since 1979, Pakistan has been used as a breeding ground for terrorists. A staggering amount of resources were pumped into Pakistan's economy to fight the Soviets. During the Afghan Jihad, Pakistan was at the centre of the stage of world politics. Scores of people were radicalised to ensure a strategic victory for the US. Little attention was paid to dismantling the residual potential of the radical ideology that was employed. Since radicalisation of this region was an international effort, counter-radicalisation (which is a part of counter-narrative) should also be facilitated by the international actors.

Furthermore, on the level of the state, Pakistan's emphasis on hard counter-terrorism strategies has helped it kill terrorists. For terrorism to be eradicated, the state must ensure a religious, ideological and philosophical rebuttal to the ideological framework which provides strength to the terrorists' agenda. There should be consensus within the clergy against terrorism. Regardless of sectarian biases and political inclinations, the

religious elite should be on one page against terrorism. Paigham-e-Pakistan has been able to achieve this consensus; the problem lies with its dissemination. The state should exercise care in choosing its messengers. Even a strong message loses its strength if it is endorsed by the wrong parties. The dissemination of the message is another challenge in itself, the messengers who are to be trusted with the message should have strong social credibility. They must come from within the society in order for the general public to trust them. For example, the Dispute Resolution Councils in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province of Pakistan are composed of local elders who are trusted by the community. If the state manages to involve such messengers in the dissemination of Paigham-e-Pakistan, the chances of its success shall increase manifold. Up until now there has been an inexplicable delay in popularising the Paigham-e-Pakistan doctrine. There should be a legislative change in favour of the Paigham-e-Pakistan doctrine, making it a part of the syllabus for secondary and higher secondary school students. In addition to this, madrassah students should also be taught this document in order to subdue the radicalisation effect that is persistent in most madrassahs across the country, especially in rural areas. The introduction of the said document in the education system (including the madrassahs) can also help in reducing the cost of spreading the message because the education system in itself provides a very pertinent and functional platform for dissemination of the narrative.

Another problem that lies at the heart of establishing an effective counter-narrative is that most efforts have thus far been undertaken by the military leadership of the country. Contrarily, the civilian leadership should take charge in giving the counter-narrative. As mentioned earlier, the Armed Forces are party to the conflict. Any message that comes from the Armed Forces is more likely to be taken as propaganda by the subjects of ideational change. For example, youth from North Waziristan is not likely to change after listening to a song or watching a drama that has been produced by the media wing of the Armed Forces. However, he or she might pay more heed to the same message if it is being delivered by the imam of the local mosque or any other social elder.

In addition to this, another modality for bringing about change is that ex-combatants like Ehsan Ullah Ehsan should be employed to de-radicalise potential terrorists and other ex-combatants in addition to using their experience to distance society for the terrorist ideology at large. According to a RAND Corp study, Indonesia has used this model to de-radicalise terrorists very effectively (Rabasa et al., p110). Ex-combatants precisely know the conditions which give birth to terrorism. Therefore, it is in the larger interest of the state to employ such ex-combatants effectively in denouncing terrorism and counter-radicalising individuals.

In totality, in every case where the state has tried to counter violent extremism through ideology, the essential elements of BCM and Aristotle's teachings were not in sync. For example, if the message was strong, the messengers were inefficient and so on. In order to mount a successful counter-narrative, all the boxes of the BCM must be checked. The message must be clear and logical yet emotionally appealing. The messenger must be credible and socially acceptable. The audience must be selected with surgical precision. Pakistan has been afforded a great opportunity in the form of Paigham-e-Pakistan where the message is clear and logical, yet appeals to the emotions. It is also endorsed by reliable and credible authors. What remains is its popularisation to the selected audiences. For that to occur, there must be substantial data on potential terrorists so that the state can use its meagre resources optimally.

Notes

1. In an interview dated 21st May 1947, with Doon Campbell, Reuters' correspondent in New Delhi, Jinnah maintained that 'the theory of Pan-Islamism has long ago exploded'. Please refer to the work of Z.H. Zaidi (1993).
2. Presence of authoritarian regime, wide-spread poverty and corruption, Jihadi infrastructure and a volatile borderland.
3. For details see Peter R. Lavoy, 'Pakistan's Strategic Culture', available at <https://fas.org/irp/agency/dod/dtra/pakistan.pdf>. Also refer to 'Strategic Culture of Pakistan', by Prof. Hassan Askari Rizvi.

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